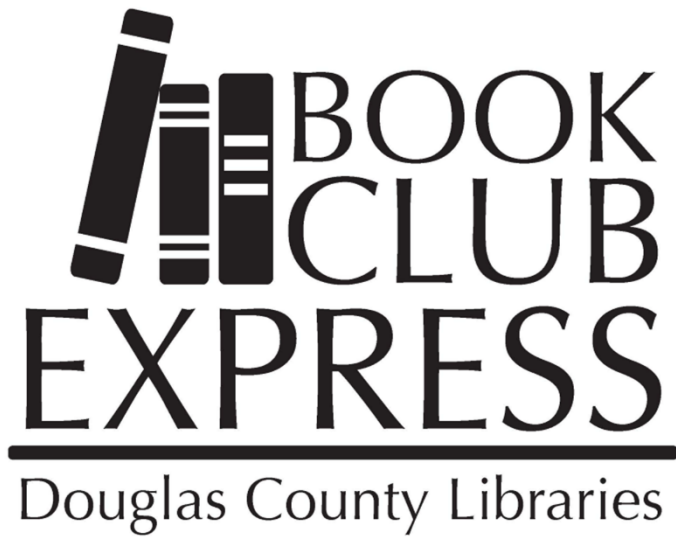




The Road to Tender Hearts

by Annie Hartnett

Look inside for
Discussion Questions
Author Interview/Biography
Reviews

Discussion Questions

- 1.How does PJ Halliday's past, including the estrangement with his daughter and the collapse of his marriage, influence his decisions throughout the story?
- 2.How does winning the lottery affect PJ's life, and how does it affect his relationships?
- 3.Discuss the significance of PJ's decision to drive across the country to reunite with Michelle Cobb. What does this journey signify for him?
- 4.What is the importance of Pancakes in the story? How does the cat's presence affect PJ and the other characters?
- 5.Do you think PJ would've been able to make the trip if he hadn't received guardianship over Ollie and Luna?
- 6.Sophie and PJ are at odds with each other during most of the road trip. How does their relationship evolve over the course of the book?
- 7.How do Ollie and Luna help in PJ's transformation from the beginning to the end? How do they help him confront his problems?
- 8.Discuss the theme of second chances in the book. How do PJ's experiences reflect the possibility of redemption?
- 9.Discuss the portrayal of aging and health in the book. How do PJ's heart attacks and his concerns about his health influence the narrative?
- 10.What message does The Road to Tender Hearts convey about family? What was the biggest lesson you learned?

Author Interview

RACHEL REEHER: For starters, what is it like to write a third book? How has the process or approach changed for you since your first book?

ANNIE HARTNETT: I'm going to mix up the children's taunt for this answer: first is the best, second is the worst, third is the one with the polka dotted chest.

I loved writing and revising my first book, *Rabbit Cake*. It went through so many iterations, but I had the patience and the time to play around to see what worked.

Unlikely Animals was my hardest to write—partially because of life circumstances (a baby, COVID lockdown, no childcare, waking up at 3:30 a.m. to write), and partially because that book was a really complicated puzzle. Anyone who has read that book probably can understand why it was hard to write.

The Road to Tender Hearts took me less time to write than the other two books did (two years, which feels like it should be a world record) because I have a better understanding of how a novel works and what I aim to do with a book, but also the speed with which I wrote this one gave me more self-doubts about it (and yes, I know two years is not that fast, no one is actually coming to my house with the world record). So on one hand, it was easier to write, and on the other hand, it's the only book I've ever cried about on the phone with my editor.

I am constantly looking for the way for writing a novel to be a completely mentally healthy activity, but I think it's a damned-if-you, damned-if-you-don't situation, meaning that I'm depressed if I'm not writing, but I am kind of ... um, unhinged ... when I'm in the middle of a novel.

But here are some things that I have found that help!

1. Turn off your internet while you're writing
2. Track your progress—I used to use an excel spreadsheet, now I've graduated to keeping a sticker chart in my kitchen which I stole from the writer Catherine Newman (500 words = 1 sticker, aim for 5 stickers a week),
3. Schedule a writing retreat. Especially if you have kids. Some of the most important work on *The Road to Tender Hearts* was done in two writing retreats: 10 days at MacDowell (my favorite place in the world), and then 4 days at an airbnb 20 minutes from my house. I wrote 26,000 words in those 4 days. And took 4 baths and read an entire book.
4. Have some kind of writing group. I'm in a writing group with the writers Tessa Fontaine, Clare Beams, and Rufi Thorpe, and we meet every two weeks to talk about writing and publishing

problems. We don't read each other's work until the book is done, but those meetings really keep me on track.

And, I do have to plug here, if you don't have a writing group, please come join The Accountability Workshops, where Tessa and I help writers with all of the above...how to fit writing into their life and keep a healthy relationship with their art. Because those who struggle most, teach best!

RR: The heart of this story, as the title hints, really is the dichotomy of tenderness—the way that it can be both healing and destructive. PJ, the central character, is in many ways bumbling and disastrous, but also full of this refreshingly naive hope. Can you speak to the role of tenderness and how it developed over the course of writing the book?

AH: I named the book *The Road to Tender Hearts* early on in the draft, and sometimes the title sets me up for what sort of exploration I want to do. I don't know how writers manage writing a book without naming their drafts, actually ... I always name the books early on. *Rabbit Cake* was titled on the first day I started the book. *Unlikely Animals* was originally titled *The Creatures We Love the Most*, which is actually still the title I prefer, but my dad told me he could never remember a title that long, and he got in my head, so I changed it.

I think that question of tenderness is something I like to explore generally in fiction—how the difficult things that happen to us can make us closed off to loving, or can teach us how to love more. I guess I like to pummel my characters into tenderness. You know, I would like to pummel a lot of people into being more accepting and loving, but I'm only allowed to do that in fiction.

RR: Two of your three novels center around children, and the way that you write child characters always has this deep sense of knowing. The narration gives their perspectives and experiences a validation that the world doesn't often afford children. What is your approach to writing children and how do you accomplish that?

AH: I love writing children, they're much more fun than writing adults. Children say exactly what they think, they don't have a filter, and they can be honest and even mean without being cruel. They say funny things all the time. Children have clear interests and hobbies. Over time, we become watered-down versions of who we were as children—less emotional, less honest, less loving, and also, often less interested in our true passions and hobbies because we have to make time for all our responsibilities. Every child is an expert in their hobby. For me, I was obsessed with horses. Too much other stuff is in my brain now for me to remember the entire anatomy of a horse, but one time I knew it. Now I just remember random words. Forelock. Frog. The dock. Gaskin? Is that one? Not sure.

RR: Do you find that a lot of your own life ends up in your writing?

AH: Yes and no—I do write about my real feelings about the world, but I don’t write directly about my own life. Mostly, I take scraps and emotions from my real life and put it all in the imagination machine and it comes out totally mangled and that’s fiction.

So here’s a true scrap for example: my grandparents really did make lollipop trees when I was a kid. My grandpa would use twist-ties to hang lollipops from the branches of a tree. I used that in the book, but in fiction, you make it bigger.

RR: You co-host a podcast about the intersection of parenting and writing, and mothers feature heavily in your novels, often as catalysts of major plot. Has your own experience of motherhood shaped the way you write mothers?

AH: I think parenthood has deepened my love of people in general, especially children, and I think empathy is good for fiction. This book was born from my anxiety about parenting, and how anyone can care for children when you have so many things to worry about all the time ... but it’s usually not the mother characters in any of my books who are doing the caretaking. The mothers usually die or run away? If we’re talking the literal mothers and not the mother-figures. The mother-figures are more where I explore my feelings about caretaking, because it’s easier to explore deep feelings from a slant angle.

RR: In the book there are moments where we briefly hear the thoughts of animals or inanimate objects. It creates a kind of chorus throughout the book. Kate’s hat, the buzzards, the cat. Can you talk about the decision to incorporate these voices?

AH: I love magical realism and I just generally look for ways for a fictional world to be MORE than our regular world. I also want to delight the reader—what’s more delightful than a group of buzzards hissing a prayer of protection for the two children to stay alive?

RR: What is your relationship to “inspiration”? Is it something you believe in? Wait for? Does it impact your writing life?

AH: I do believe in it! I get hit over the head with it sometimes. When we drove to see this house we live in now, I said to my husband, if we move here, I can write another book about this place. I’m very inspired by place. And then I write about scraps from my past, movies I’ve seen, music I listen to, and mix it all together in my brain. Every novel is like a soup of inspiration and memories and whatever happens when you sit in the chair for long enough and just type.

RR: So much tragedy befalls these characters, not only within the book, but long before it begins. And at the same time, the novel is full of so much silliness and fun. How do you strike that balance?

AH: There was a review of my first book, *Rabbit Cake*, (which was, in its whole, a lovely review and I feel like I should apologize to the reviewer every time I bring this up because I’m not mad

at her) that had one line that bothered me in it—“Sometimes Hartnett veers toward the silly.” It bothered me because it’s something I think is true of my work, and then became something I was self-conscious about, but eventually, I decided to own it. I am not a serious person. I am very sensitive and aware of all the real badness that is happening in the world, but I’m also just a person who reaches for the joke to help us all cope. My friend Ruffi Thorpe said to me—“yes, you always make us laugh. But that’s when you slide the knife in.” Or vice versa!—I’ll slide the knife in but I’ll tell you jokes all the way to the hospital and by the time we get there you will have dropped charges and we’re in love and planning our wedding. That’s what I hope for, for us to be deeply connected by the end.

RR: Is that connectedness something that you’re making conscious decisions about throughout the writing process, or something you find your way into? I guess I’m asking whether that’s a defined target that guides you, or if you look back when you’re finished and find that it’s there.

AH: I’m always trying to heal broken characters by the end, and trying to teach myself/and the reader to look at the beauty in the world, and to keep finding joy and amusement even in darkness. I went to see the school therapist once in college, and she asked me when was the last time I felt joy, and I was so haunted by it. I thought it was a crazy question—*Joy? Who feels joy?* And since then, I’ve noticed, I feel joy all the time. But it happens in bursts. You don’t walk around in joy all the time. So throughout the book, there are bursts of joy. And that’s why, when the little girl asks the cat what’s going to happen to her and her brother, the cat answers: “Suffering. And joy.” That’s my favorite line in the book. That’s really what I write about. Suffering, joy, and the human connection around both.

Author Biography

Annie Hartnett is the author of three novels: RABBIT CAKE (Tin House Books, 2017), UNLIKELY ANIMALS (Ballantine/Random House, 2022) and THE ROAD TO TENDER HEARTS (Ballantine/Random House, April 2025).

THE ROAD TO TENDER HEARTS is Annie's newest novel, a national bestseller and winner of the 2025 New England Book Award. It received starred reviews from Kirkus and Booklist and was an April Indie Next Pick.

Unlikely Animals was listed as one of the best books of 2022 by the Washington Post and BookRiot. It was the winner of the 2023 Julia Ward Howe prize for fiction, and was longlisted for the Joyce Carol Oates Prize. It was the April 2022 book club selection for Good Housekeeping magazine and Amerie's Book club. It received starred reviews from Booklist and Bookpage, and was an April Indie Next pick.

Rabbit Cake was listed as one of Kirkus Reviews' Best Books of 2017, was a finalist for the New England Book Award, an Indies Introduce and an Indie Next Pick, and was long-listed for the Center for Fiction's First Novel Prize. It received starred reviews from Publisher's Weekly, Kirkus, and Library Journal, and was People magazine's Book of the Week.

Annie has been awarded fellowships and residencies from the MacDowell, Sewanee Writers' Conference, and the Associates of the Boston Public Library. She holds degrees from the MFA program at the University of Alabama, Middlebury College's Bread Loaf School of English, and Hamilton College. She lives in Massachusetts with her husband, daughter, and dogs.

Reviews

Over the years, I have come to realize that I enjoy a good road trip novel much more than I would an actual road trip. Maybe that's partially because my expectations for what a road trip could, or should, be have been increasingly colored by those self-same books. After all, how could endless hours on the interstate compare with a fictional road trip like the one Annie Hartnett has invented, involving long-lost relatives, a slew of other colorful characters, an alligator named T. Boone Pickens, a cat who may or may not be an agent of death, and a sprinkle or two of magic?

Winning \$1.5 million in the Massachusetts state lottery might have been the best, or worst, thing that ever happened to 63-year-old PJ Halliday. Okay, it's definitely not the worst thing --- that dubious honor goes to the death of his older daughter, Kate, who drowned in a cranberry bog on the night of her senior prom. Winning the lottery, though, did give PJ just the time and money he needed to spend his days drinking himself into a stupor and pining over his ex-wife, Ivy.

"THE ROAD TO TENDER HEARTS is a big-hearted meditation on caregiving, second chances, and the miracle of living (and laughing) in the midst of death."

Now Ivy and her long-time boyfriend, Fred, are heading off to Alaska on the trip of a lifetime, and PJ is feeling lonely and bereft. Upon learning that his long-ago high school crush, Michelle Cobb, has been widowed recently, PJ hatches a plan to "borrow" Fred's car and head off to the Tender Hearts Retirement Community in Tucson, Arizona, for one last chance at happiness. Little does PJ know that a tragedy unfolding just a few blocks away in Pondville, Massachusetts, is about to upend his own life in the best way possible.

Overnight, nine-year-old Ollie and 10-year-old Luna have been orphaned as the result of a particularly grisly murder-suicide. Their grandfather was PJ's estranged brother, making PJ their closest living relative --- and their new, rather unlikely, guardian. Hell-bent on getting to Michelle, PJ invites the kids along on his road trip and enlists his recently unemployed younger daughter, Sophie, for the ride. They're also accompanied by that "agent of death" cat, Pancakes, who knows more than he's letting on.

In an author's note at the end of the book, Hartnett explains that THE ROAD TO TENDER HEARTS was born out of a challenge she set herself --- to write a funny novel about some of the worst tragedies that can befall people. It's safe to say that she succeeds. The book is wise, witty and emotional without ever veering into sappiness. PJ's journey is a literal one, but it's also metaphorical. He takes more than a few detours on his road to a sobriety that might enable him to care for these youngsters with his whole self, in a way that he still regrets not being able to do for his own daughters.

Readers who are parents themselves --- or are fond of children --- will have a hard time not tearing up at a couple of key moments in the novel, as PJ and Sophie wrap their heads around

their new roles as caregivers. *THE ROAD TO TENDER HEARTS* is a big-hearted meditation on caregiving, second chances, and the miracle of living (and laughing) in the midst of death. Pancakes sums it up near the end of the book: "Death is a magnificent invention, the cat knew, because it's the impermanence of life that makes it beautiful."

Read-Alikes

Margo's Got Money Troubles by Ruffi Thorpe

A bold, laugh-out-loud funny, and heartwarming story about one young woman's attempt to navigate adulthood, new motherhood, and her meager bank account in our increasingly online world—from the PEN/ Faulkner finalist and critically acclaimed author of *The Knockout Queen*.

Run for the Hills by Kevin Wilson

Ever since her dad left them twenty years ago, it's just been Madeline Hill and her mom on their farm in Coalfield, Tennessee. While she sometimes admits it's a bit lonely, and a less exciting a life than she imagined for herself, it's mostly OK. Mostly. Then one day, Reuben Hill pulls up in a PT Cruiser and informs Madeline that he believes she's his half-sister. Reuben--left behind by their dad thirty years ago--has hired a detective to track down their father and a string of other half siblings. And he wants Mad to leave her home and join him for the craziest kind of road trip imaginable to find them all. As Mad and Rube--and eventually the others--share stories of their father, who behaved so differently in each life he created, they begin to question what he was looking for with each new incarnation.